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Military College of Signals NUST, Islamabad, Pakistan

Correspondence to:

Riaz Ahmed,
riazkhattak450@gmail.com

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Parenting Styles and Their Influence on Child Development: A Critical Review of Contemporary Research

Riaz Ahmed

ABSTRACT

Parenting styles significantly influence various dimensions of child development, encompassing emotional, cognitive, and social outcomes. This critical review explores contemporary research to analyze the interplay between different parenting dimensions and their effects on children's developmental trajectories. The review highlights key findings on how authoritative, authoritarian, permissive, and neglectful parenting styles shape children's self-esteem, academic achievement, and emotional regulation, drawing upon diverse methodologies, including neurodevelopmental and longitudinal approaches. Existing literature underscores the importance of cultural contexts, social stratification, and gender dynamics in mediating these relationships. Despite advancements, gaps remain in understanding the long-term effects of diverse parenting practices, particularly in cross-cultural settings and underrepresented populations. Future research must incorporate big data analytics, longitudinal designs, and technology-driven interventions to address these gaps. This review offers practical implications for parents, educators, and policymakers, emphasizing the need for informed strategies that foster holistic child development in an evolving societal landscape.

Keywords: Authoritative parenting, Emotional regulation, Cross-cultural parenting, Socioeconomic status, Neurodevelopmental approaches

Introduction

Background

Parenting plays a crucial role in shaping a child's overall development, influencing their emotional, cognitive, social, and behavioral growth. The literature emphasizes the importance of parental attitudes concerning different aspects of child development processes and devotes special attention to the typology of parenting.^{1,2} Diana Baumrind's foundational framework remains central to this discourse, classifying parenting into three primary styles: *authoritative*, *authoritarian*, and *permissive*. After Maccoby and Martin developed the initial typology, the other type, *neglectful parenting*, was added to the list.^{3,4}

Importance of Parenting in Child Development

Effective parenting fosters a child's ability to thrive in diverse environments, equipping them with the skills to navigate challenges and seize opportunities.⁵ Additionally, effective or adaptive family processes can promote developmental achievements and simultaneously avert poor developmental milestones that would lead to poor behavioral, emotional, and academic results.¹

Research Problem and Rationale

In contemporary society, the complexities of parenting have increased due to technological advancements, dual-working households, and shifting cultural norms. Thus, knowledge of the existing typology of parenting practices is crucial for contemporary parents and teachers who require effective strategies for a child's growth.⁴ After discussing these styles, one can gain ideas on how best to enhance the welfare, academic achievement, and self-fulfillment of children at their tender age.³

Research Objectives

This review aims to address the following objectives:

- To define and categorize parenting styles, emphasizing their theoretical underpinnings.
- To analyze the impact of parenting styles on various developmental domains (emotional, cognitive, social, behavioral).
- To evaluate the influence of cultural and socioeconomic factors on parenting approaches and outcomes.
- To examine the interplay of parenting styles with external factors such as genetics, peer influence, and educational environments.

Research Scope

This paper critically reviews existing literature to provide a comprehensive understanding of parenting styles and their implications for child development. It discusses the principles related to types of parenting and their differences and derivatives, starting with Baumrind's original classification and continuing with subsequent extensions by other authors.^{3,4}

This research focuses on the analyses of the contribution of parenting practices as determinants of multiple domains of children's development, and it also identifies both favorable and adverse effects connected with particular types of parenting.^{1,2}

Parenting Styles: Definitions and Frameworks

Theoretical Foundations: Diana Baumrind's Parenting Style Framework

Diana Baumrind's framework for parenting styles remains one of the most influential models in psychological and educational research. The framework, which was developed in the 1960s, classifies parenting into four primary styles: parental authoritative, authoritarian, permissive, and neglectful, which are defined as responsiveness and demandingness (Figure 1).⁶

Authoritative parenting, defined by a high level of positive parental regard or simply high responsiveness

and high structuring or demandingness, is a highly effective form of parenting that positively affects child development, such as academic achievement, emotional development, and social development.⁷ *Authoritarian* parenting is characterized by demandingness but low warmth and/or negative regard, which involves subjugation, demands, and commands over autocratic control and restricted warmth and encouragement. The *permissive style* of rearing has high sensitivity but low expectations from the child. Therefore, most children are not disciplined.⁶ These basic styles have offered a conceptual framework for a half century of empirical work on the consequences of parenting for children.^{7,8} After Baumrind's original formulations, subsequent expansion and alterations to her structure incorporated the limitations and new classifications. In the 1980s, other researchers, Maccoby and Martin, added a fourth type of parenting called *neglectful*. This style is marked by low levels of responsiveness and demandingness, which in most cases lead to negative developmental

effects on children, such as lack of emotional security, poor performance, and disruptive behaviors.^{8,9} This specific category added the impact of lack of or unsatisfactory parenting, which expanded Baumrind's model and incorporated various parents' practices.

These parenting patterns are characterized by specific features that affect child results. Warm acceptance of the child characterizes authoritative parents and their authoritative child-rearing methods. They set high standards for their children, but at the same time, they fulfill their needs. This is associated with better estimates, better academic performance, and the well-being of children.^{1,7}

Authoritative parents use punishment and demand obedience in children, contributing to lower self-esteem and higher levels of stress in these children compared to the levels in other children, even though the children can be well-behaved and perform better academically in some environments.^{8,10} Authoritative parents are loving but not controlling enough to ensure that a child develops responsibility and self-control, which leads to childish behaviors and poor social skills.⁶ The only ineffective child-rearing style that is connected with the worst of the outcomes, behavioral issues, and issues with emotional self-control is cold and uninvolved but also harsh and uninvolved parenting.^{8,9} However, the measures used have become more advanced in the current studies to assess the types of parenting. PSDQ and PAQ are especially used as questionnaires to identify parenting styles. These tools use self-reported and observational data to evaluate responsiveness, demandingness, and other key dimensions of parenting.¹¹ Advances in research methodologies, such as longitudinal studies and neurodevelopmental approaches, have provided deeper insights into the dynamic interplay between parenting styles and child development.⁷

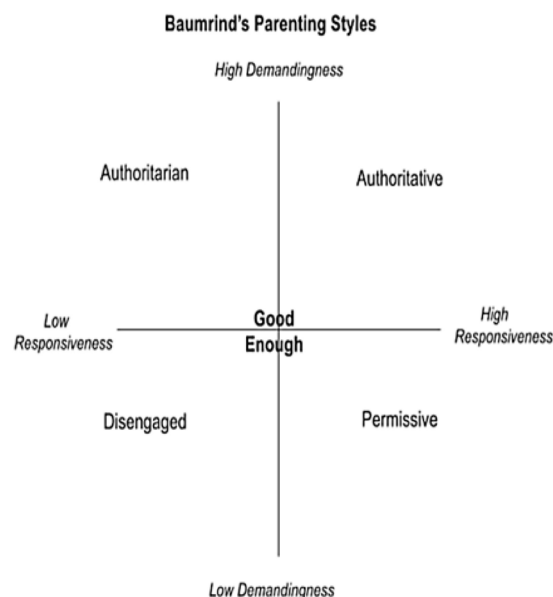


Fig 1 | Diana Baumrind's Parenting Framework by Palvidis, 2020

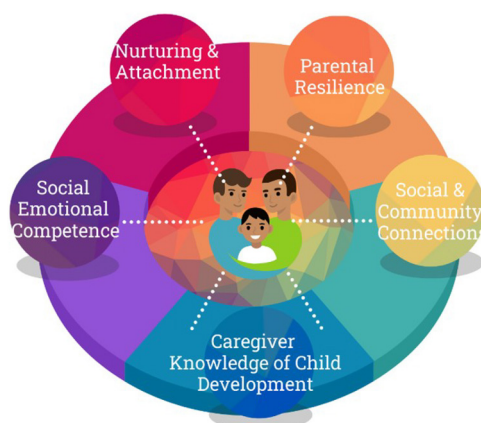


Fig 2 | Social-emotional development factors by AAP (2025)

Influence of Parenting Styles on Child Development Emotional Development

Parenting styles affect a child's attachment theory foundation and emotional regulation capabilities. Authoritative responsiveness also encourages secure base dominance and better emotional regulation because parental warmth and behavior impose limits to teach children how to regulate their feelings appropriately. On the other hand, authoritarian parenting with the strict discipline of the child tends to negatively impact the child's emotional well-being and restrict the formation of their emotional coping mechanisms.¹² In the permissive style of child-rearing, children are easily indulged, and their emotions, by and large, are not trained to be disciplined as they grow up. Thus, they act out when faced with complex tasks.¹³ A medical study that looks at parenting quality defined by emotional withdrawal or absence reveals attachment and emotional dysregulation, lifelong psychological problems (Figure 2).¹⁴

Cognitive Development

The impact of parenting styles on academic performance and problem-solving skills is well-documented.

The perennially pressuring parents with high demands but with support stimulate the child's curiosity, persistence, and academic self-concepts, thus producing a better academic performance.¹⁵ Moreover, authoritarian parenting helps to achieve obedience and academic performance at the price of imagination and self-organization.¹² Parenting with low demands and no set correctional rules will have poor academic performance because the child is not well-guided or corrected.¹³ On the other hand, a lack of parental supervision is positively connected with low academic achievement and a low level of impulse control, as children in these homes do not receive competent stimulation for cognition improvement (Figure 3).

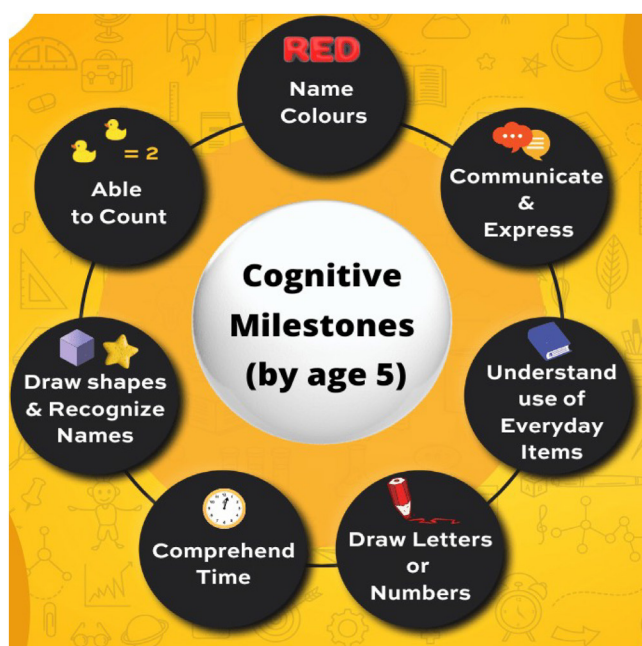


Fig 3 | Cognitive development in children by CLL (2025)



Fig 4 | Benefits of social-emotional development by INC (2023)

Social Development

Parenting practices shape peer relationships, empathy, and communication skills. Authoritative parenting fosters obedience, respect, and the use of appropriate language, fostering social competence and responsible and positive regard for peers.^{8,10} Authoritative parenting while teaching discipline hinders the child's social competence, reducing direct communication and, therefore, social interaction.¹⁰ The kind of socialization promoted by the permissive style of parenting is that children learn poor conflict-solving skills because there are no proper restraints. The worst parenting style of the four is negligent, and fathers who do not spend time with their children end up with kids that have few friends, cannot comprehend the feelings of others, nor interact with them appropriately (Figure 4).¹⁴

Behavioral Development

Parenting styles also influence discipline, self-control, and risk-taking behaviors. Authoritative rearing represents self-discipline and acceptable risk-taking, giving the child the self-confidence and framework necessary to make wise choices.^{12,15} On the other hand, authoritarian parenting, with enforced obedience-oriented regulations, hinders self-regulation. In situations requiring individuals to exercise personal discretion, they become overly compliant or defiant.¹⁰ This is true, especially because permissive parents do not enforce rules. Hence, the children do not develop adequate self-control over their actions.¹³ Lack of attentiveness is one of the key factors in the child becoming delinquent since, in such households, the child learns to look for acceptance and rules from outside his home.¹⁴

Cultural and Socioeconomic Contexts

Cultural variations deeply influence parenting styles, particularly when comparing collectivist and individualist societies. Subculture sources can be identified in collectivist cultures typical for Asia, Africa, and Latin America, with core values such as interdependence, family duties, and people's common row. In such a system, an authoritarian parenting style is more commonly observed because it is in consonance with the culture of obedience and respect for authority. Although these practices appear harsh from a traditional child psychodevelopment perspective in Western societies, they correlate positively with desirable development psychology, which comprise duties toward family members and order in collectivist societies.¹⁶ Authoritative parenting is more frequent in these situations as it combines independence with rules and directions, fostering both academic and social success.¹⁷

The influence of socioeconomic status (SES) on parenting approaches is significant, shaping both the resources available to parents and their ability to implement specific styles effectively. Many high SES parents use authoritative parenting because they have more resources such as books, physical activities, and even professional consultations. However, these resources allow them to develop a conducive environment of care and discipline, fostering cognitive and emotional growth.¹⁸

Looking at the possible effects of SES, it is clear that it plays a particularly influential role for a child because it determines the child's exposure to the opportunities and factors that make up the social context in which development occurs. Children in high SES households are likely to be exposed to more valuable inputs that reflect on their human capital, namely, quality education, quality health, and any other improvements that would make them better human beings in the future. While low SES entails more stress, the lack of a stable home, and inadequate education in childhood, high SES does not offer means to counter the above effects. Due to these factors, learners have poor self-regulation of their emotions; they perform poorly academically and have poor health; they end up disadvantaged lifelong.¹⁹

Interplay of Parenting Styles with Other Influences

Parenting styles interact with genetic predispositions, highlighting the complex interplay between nature and nurture in shaping child outcomes. Temperament is determined *inter alia* by genes, and cognitive and emotional quotient, while how these attributes are exhibited depends on the parenting style. For example, children with a genetic component consisting of anxiety will demonstrate fewer symptoms in authoritative homes since there shall be structures provided with the necessary support. On the other hand, authoritarian or neglecting parental care is likely to worsen such a state because parenting plays a crucial role in shaping the child's emotional and psychological well-being.²⁰ It has been determined that parenting and genetics have a reciprocal relation, meaning that while certain genes can lead to certain outcomes triggering specific parenting behaviors, general developmental patterns are affected.²¹

The impact of peer groups, the media, and educational situations also modifies parenting styles' effects on children. Playgroups also gain importance as kids grow older, helping them learn behavior and other aspects of personality development. Authoritative parenting has been linked to children in aspects of positive peer relations since the approach cultivates empathy, communication, and problem-solving abilities in a child. The final influence is media exposure, which can support or oppose parentage advice. Children who grow up in permissive homes may not be given adequate direction when analyzing messages conveyed in media. In contrast, those growing up in authoritative homes are more likely to handle media content constructively.²²

Coparenting and blended family dynamics introduce additional layers of complexity. In shared parenting relationships or harmonization of parenting, a stronger correlation of the family parenting model retards the child's growth. Authoritative parenting and authoritarian, or permissive and indulgent, are two opposite modes that confuse the kid and undermine developmental results.

On the other hand, cooperative parenting enhances the impact of a selected mode, including when

both caregivers embrace an authoritative strategy. Of course, blended families can be problematic because a child may experience the collation of parenting styles of a biological parent and a step-parent. These dynamics typically require a free flow of communication between the caregivers to support the child, particularly where a sense of respect for one another has been established; this adds predictability to the child's life.²⁰ Scholars recognize their importance in moderating the impact of parenting behaviors. For example, a child's predisposing factors of emotional dysregulation may be reduced by enhanced and positive peer pressure and proper parental care.^{22,23}

Contemporary Challenges in Parenting Technology and Digital Media

The widespread use of technology and digital media has significantly altered parent-child interactions and supervision. Technology in education can contribute to added content and variety in learning; overuse and access to the internet have detrimental effects on the child's learning ability, emotional well-being, and social interaction.²⁴ Guardians are sometimes pushed to the limit regarding setting rules on when and what a child is allowed to watch, and often, in today's busy world, both parents are working and hence cannot spend a lot of time supervising. An example from the research area is the decline in the use of face-to-face communication in families and decreased emotional connection due to increased reliance on technology.^{24,25}

Dual-Working Parents and Time Constraints

The increasing prevalence of dual-working parents introduces challenges related to time constraints and work-life balance. Couples employed in both jobs experience challenges in providing sufficient parenting time, which may be accompanied by a lack of caregiving and monitoring. Lack of time is the last root cause that can entice inconsistent parenting practices, leading to children requiring outside help or technology. Both studies emphasize that though the parents face these barriers, good time management and shared care, given the diminution of parental availability, can lessen the negative implications.^{24,26}

Mental Health Challenges for Parents and Children

Mental health challenges are a pressing concern in contemporary parenting. Families suffering from stress, anxiety, or depression may not cope kindly with their children and may not be able to offer sensitive socialization responses; hence, the emotional security of their children may be at risk.²⁴ The cross-sectional interaction between parental and child mental health, where every difficulty with either the parent or child will influence the other, is a common fact that has been established. For example, the transition to parenthood and reintegration into parenthood is associated with increased overall levels of stress and relational conflict, which consequently compromises relational satisfaction and actual parenting capacities. Effective management of such disorders using support structures,

Table 1 | Inclusion and exclusion criteria

Criteria	Inclusion	Exclusion
Publication date	Studies published between 2019 and 2025	Studies published before 2019
Language	Studies available in English	Studies in languages other than English
Type of study	Empirical studies, systematic reviews, meta-analyses, and longitudinal research	Opinion pieces, editorials, or case reports not backed by empirical data
Population	Studies involving children aged 0 – 18 years and their parents	Studies focusing exclusively on adult populations or unrelated age groups
Focus on parenting styles	Research explicitly analyzing parenting styles (authoritative, authoritarian, permissive, neglectful)	Studies that do not categorize parenting approaches or focus on unrelated family dynamics
Cultural Context	Studies discussing cultural, socioeconomic, or cross-cultural aspects of parenting styles	Studies lacking contextual analysis of culture or socioeconomic variables
Outcomes measured	Emotional, cognitive, social, and behavioral outcomes in children	Studies that do not measure or report child developmental outcomes
Accessibility	Full-text studies available through open access or institutional subscriptions	Abstract-only studies or those behind paywalls without institutional access

counseling, and therapy interventions provides a basis for enhancing the caregiver-child relationship.^{25,26}

Critical Review of Methodologies

This review employed a systematic approach to identify and analyze studies relevant to parenting styles and their influence on child development. The inclusion and exclusion criteria were designed to ensure a focused and comprehensive review of contemporary research.^{2,27} The process of study selection is detailed below.

Process of Selection

- **Database Search:** PubMed, PsycInfo, and Scopus were used in the literature review. The following keywords were used: “parenting styles,” “child development,” “authoritative parenting,” “cross-cultural parenting,” and “socioeconomic.”
- **Initial Screening:** Titles and abstracts were then truncated to eliminate nonrelevant articles and studies and eventual duplicate records.
- **Full-Text Screening:** The researches were filtered by primary and secondary parameters to check their relevance to the topic.
- **Quality Assessment:** Effectiveness was evaluated based on methodological characteristics of the reviewed studies, such as the sample size, analysis type, and the reporting degree.
- **Final Selection:** To carry out the present review, all research that met the inclusion criteria was only considered for further analysis.

Inclusion and Exclusion Criteria (See Table 1) *Research Designs Commonly Used in Studies on Parenting and Child Development*

Research on parenting and child development often employs observational studies, cross-sectional surveys, and longitudinal research to examine the relationship between parenting practices and developmental outcomes. Subtypes of randomized controlled trials (RCTs), which are experimental designs, are

commonly applied in assessing parenting programs and their effectiveness on early child development. According to one study, only RCTs were chosen to analyze the positive impact of improved cognitive and socio-emotional development in children aged up to three years.²⁸ These studies underline the need for a system approach to evaluating parenting provisions in different environments.

Limitations in Existing Research

Despite advancements in methodologies, significant **limitations** persist. This is especially true of the sample, many of which are still predominantly drawn from Western, Educated, Industrialized, Rich, and Democratic (WEIRD) countries. This bias restricts the conclusions that could be made across the use of the scale in another cultural and economic setting.^{27,29} Furthermore, follow-up information, particularly important for assessing change rates in subjects, is comparably restrained because the costs of and organizational requirements for such studies are high.²⁸ It is noteworthy, however, that values and cultural biases are also embedded in parenting research, where many theoretical models tend to endorse Western standards for the correct style of child-rearing. Moreover, parental gendered practices and their developmental consequences are understudied in non-Western countries, which weakens the opportunity to explain cultural variation in the framework of parenting.²⁹

Advances in Research Methodologies

Recent advances in research methodologies have begun addressing these limitations.²⁸ Neurodevelopmental methods involving neuroimaging and psychophysiological measurements offer an understanding of the effects of parenting practices on a child's brain and self-regulation. For example, the authors examined the relational health perspective that employs neurodevelopmental findings to analyze the reciprocal effects of parent-children interactions on health statuses.³⁰

Gaps in Research and Future Directions

Despite significant progress in understanding the relationship between parenting and child development, critical gaps remain. Numerous works have established distinct conventional parenting types, but few works exist concerning fresh parenting styles determined by innovations and family organization systems. For example, the concept of digital parenting about cognitive, emotional, and social development has not been researched adequately. Morawska (2020) stresses that gendered parenting practices have been discussed sparingly in various cultural contexts, and thus, there is a lack of understanding of how these roles impact child outcome alleles.²⁹

Novel Contributions

New frameworks such as collaborative parenting networks and flexible work policies are essential to address contemporary parenting challenges. *Collaborative networks* and *shared decision making (SDM)* can offer resources and services from which parents can

share responsibilities.³¹ Telecommuting and flexible schedules are important in managing working and family responsibilities for managing parents' work and family responsibilities. Consequently, embedding mental health promotion into parenting programs may help parents learn how to help themselves and their children.³² They may enhance a positive pattern of parenting that increases support and adaptability to modern family situations (Figure 5).

Modern Relevance

Digital parenting, dual-working households, and mental health are critical aspects of contemporary parenting. Digital parenting refers to helping children control the information they access through technology when using the internet and the kind of content they search.³⁰ In dual-working households, there are observable strategies that two working adults can use

to juggle work schedules and family responsibilities. Parental mental health is emerging as a prominent concept to enhance stress and support parents' and children's emotional health.³³ It is essential to address these areas so that many families can develop healthy interactions and parents can be in a position to address some of the issues that life entails (Figure 6).

Practical Applications

In light of the current parenting challenges, teachers, leaders, and parents can incorporate the following insights. Teachers as actors can incorporate digital literacy and mental health courses as instructions offered to the learners and their parents.³⁴ Employer champions can, therefore, work with policymakers to develop pro-family policies, including paid parental leave and flexible working to accommodate more dual-breadwinner families. They can guide their children in developing timetables and schedules, communicate clearly, and involve outside agencies.³⁰ In implementing the above strategies, stakeholders ensure a favorable atmosphere for the family and the development of the parents and children.

Conclusion

In conclusion, exploring parenting styles and their influence on child development underscores the profound role parents play in shaping children's emotional, cognitive, social, and behavioral trajectories. Key findings suggest that by the authoritative parents' model, the child is best provided for across the zones of development, while with permissive, neglectful, and authoritarian parents, the results are mixed or negative. Forcing this relationship through different methodologies allows for moderate generalizations and conclusions, as cultural and socioeconomic differences or the interplay between parenting and other factors such as peer groups, educational settings, and media compound this relationship. Current issues and complications like the incorporation of technology in our lives, working parents, and even issues to do with mental health among parents only cement the fact that parenting is a dynamic process.

Suggestions for Future Studies

Future research directions can be proposed:

1. *Incorporation of Technology:* Future studies should investigate how parents use technology to influence developmental outcomes, including the role of digital tools in communication, learning, and supervision. Jeong et al. (2021) suggest that parenting interventions could benefit from integrating technological solutions, such as mobile applications, to enhance accessibility and impact.²⁸
2. *Longitudinal Studies:* There is a pressing need for longitudinal research that tracks the long-term effects of parenting styles on child development across different life stages. Such studies would provide deeper insights into how early parenting influences later outcomes in adolescence and adulthood. Frosch et al. (2021) advocate for longitudinal

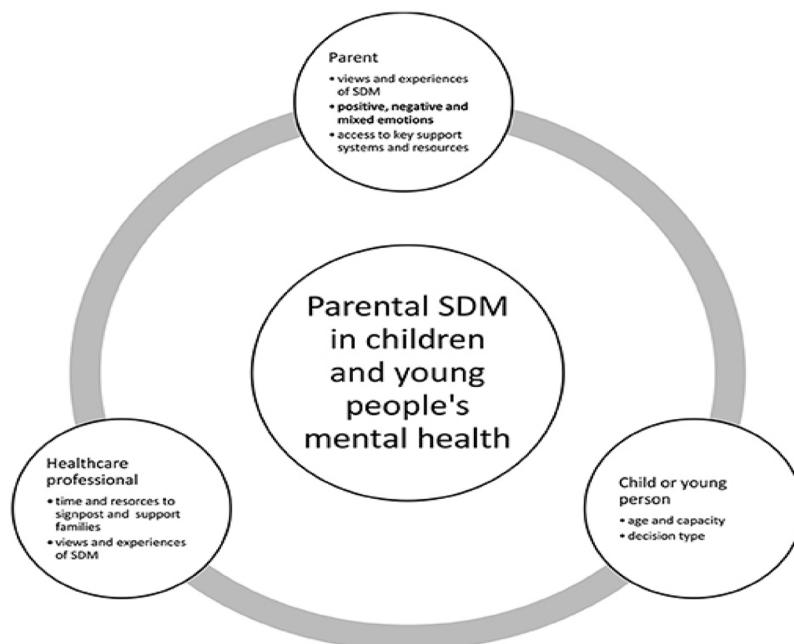


Fig 5 | Parental SDM in children and young people's mental health

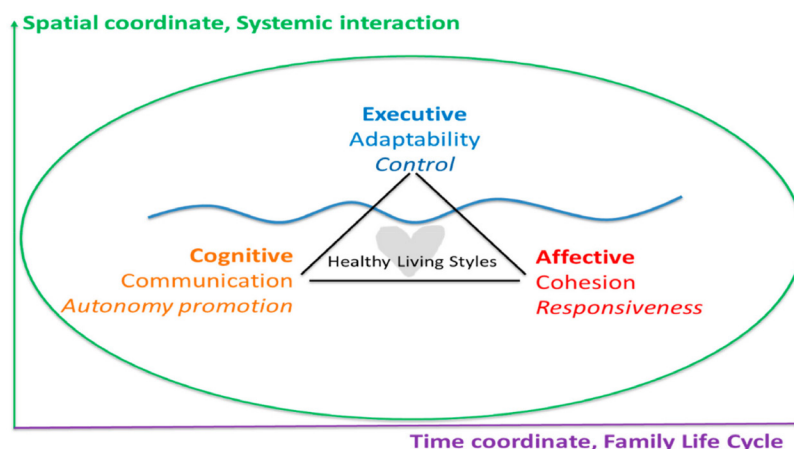


Fig 6 | Parenting styles that affect healthy lifestyles by Alonso-Stuyck (2019)

approaches to better understand relational health and its developmental implications over time.³⁰

3. *Cross-Cultural Comparisons:* Conducting cross-cultural comparisons is crucial for addressing the cultural biases currently dominating the literature. Future research should explore parenting styles and child outcomes in non-Western contexts to build a more comprehensive understanding of global parenting practices. Morawska (2020) emphasizes the importance of studying culturally specific parenting styles, especially in collectivist societies, to broaden the scope of existing frameworks.²⁹
4. *Interdisciplinary Approaches:* Collaborative research combining sociology, neuroscience, and education could provide multidimensional insights into parenting. Big data analytics and neurodevelopmental tools, as suggested by Cano (2022), offer promising avenues for uncovering complex relationships between parenting and child development.²⁷

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